Kavya Ravindranath

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Education

George Washington University
Ph.D. Economics, expected May 2027

Madras School of Economics, India
M.A. Economics, 2019

St. Xavier's College, India
B.A. Economics, 2017

Fields

Primary: Public Economics, Development Economics
Secondary: Political Economy, Environmental Economics

References

Dr. Elira Kuka
ekuka@gwu.edu

Dr. Tanner Regan
tanner_regan@gwu.edu

Dr. Paul Carrillo
pcarrill@gwu.edu

Dr. Remi Jedwab
jedwab@gwu.edu

Working Papers

Raising Revenues: Evidence from Property Tax Assessments in India *(Job Market Paper)*

Abstract: How do property-owners respond to increases in property-tax liabilities? Particularly, do these responses differ across the initial-liability distribution, and how does accounting for this heterogeneity affect the revenue-maximizing tax rate? I construct a novel dataset of geolocated properties and digitised parcel-level maps from an Indian municipality to answer these questions. I exploit variation in liabilities that arise from area-based guidance values that are fixed as of 2011, known as 'circle rates'. First, I find that a 1% increase in the circle rate reduces compliance by 0.45% but increases total revenues by 0.85%. A model-based exercise implies that revenues are maximized by scaling every circle rate by a common factor of 4.011. This preserves the existing relative circle rate schedule while increasing liabilities proportionally across properties, and is equivalent to increasing the statutory tax rate from 0.25% to 1.00%. Second, I find statistically significant differences in compliance elasticities across the circle rate distribution, with larger responses at higher rates. Incorporating this reduces the revenue-maximizing scaling factor to 2.217, equivalent to increasing the statutory tax rate to 0.55%. Third, I find that updating liabilities to reflect revenue maximising schedules leads to large gains in revenue, but simply updating outdated circle rates to more recent values recovers a substantial share of these gains.

Bridging the Solar Divide: Demand Responses to Subsidies among Low-Income Households with Rui Zhong

Abstract: Governments increasingly rely on subsidies to encourage household adoption of clean technology, yet credible estimates of demand elasticities for low-income households, remain limited. In this paper, we study demand responses to solar subsidies in California, using an RDD and find a large price elasticity of -1.73. Low-income households are sensitive to the price they pay but may be served better by smaller panels that cost less.

Political Economy of State Borrowing and Financial Crowding Out with Viral Acharya, Nirupama Kulkarni, and Rahul Singh Chauhan

Abstract: Using regulatory primary auction data of state government securities, we find states with the same ruling party as the central government increase issuance by 28% at 43 bps lower yields in the year before elections. The crowding out mechanism operates through government-owned banks, who bid 23% higher amounts and at a 70 bps discount relative to other bidders. Consequently, firms with a 10% higher share of PSB borrowing see a 9.3% reduction in debt. Finally, we establish the underlying political economy channel wherein aligned states increase consumption expenditure, which increases the probability of the ruling party getting re-elected.

Papers in Progress

Pass-Through of Consumption Taxes under Political Pressure with Sai Pitre

Digital Land and Property Improvement Tax Payment Mechanism in Malawi
with Klaus W. Deininger and Daniel Ayalew Ali
Link to pre-registered trial

How much influence does a bureaucrat have? A study of caste and crime in India

Policy Publications

Progressive tax rate bands and the state of property tax in Kampala
with Nathaniel Badalov, Julius Mutebi, Tanner Regan and Ezra Ssebuwufu
International Growth Centre, 2025

Understanding Sovereign Ratings and Their Implications for Emerging Economies
with Nirupama Kulkarni, Gautham Udupa, Kaushalendra Kishore, Ilisa Goenka and Rahul Singh Chauhan
Economic & Political Weekly, 2023

Seminars & Conferences

2027 - ASSA [+] (Poster)
2026 - World Bank/IFS/ODI Tax Conference (Discussant), Georgetown DMV PhD Conference on Political Economy & Development[+], NEUDC[+], NTA[+], APPAM[*+]
2023 - World Bank/IFS/ODI Tax Conference
[*] *Presented by co-author,* [+]*Scheduled*

Research Experience

Consultant - World Bank Group DECRG, Dec 2025–Aug 2026; *PI: Dr. Klaus Deininger*
Research Associate, 2025–2026; *PI: Dr. Elira Kuka*
Consultant - International Finance Corporation, Summer 2025
Research Associate, Summer 2023, Summer 2024; *PI: Dr. Tanner Regan*
Research Associate - Energy and Environment Lab, University of Chicago, Summer 2022; *PIs: Dr. Fiona Burlig and Dr. Ludovica Gazze*
Research Associate - Center for Advanced Financial Research and Learning, Reserve Bank of India, 2019–2021; *PI: Dr. Nirupama Kulkarni*

Fellowships & Awards

Lincoln Institute of Land Policy C. Lowell Harriss Dissertation Fellowship: 2026
John W. Kendrick Endowed Summer Award: 2023, 2024, 2025
GW CCAS Doctoral Fellowship: 2021 – 2025

Memberships

NTA, AEA, APPAM, AREUEA

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Principles of Microeconomics: Fall 2021: *Prof Anthony Yezer*; Spring 2021, Fall 2022, Fall 2024: *Prof Daniel Mackay*
Teaching Assistant, Principles of Macroeconomics: Spring 2022, Fall 2023: *Prof Ronald Bird*; Spring 2024: *Prof Roberto Samaniego*
Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Econometrics: Spring 2025: *Prof Alessandra Fenizia*

Technical skills

Software: Stata, Python, LaTeX, R, SQL
GIS: QGIS, ArcGIS
Other: Git, Qualtrics, Tableau

Citizenship

India, valid work authorization for the United States